

when you go out of your way to jazz them up, they are still low on the work scale. Add in some quartered baby portabellas, almonds, shallots, or even a bacon and parmesan combo accent. Too much effort? Olive oil and pre-minced garlic will do just fine.

4. Spicy black beans

This is a trick I picked up from my favorite Mexican restaurant of all time, Cafe Noche in Conway Village, New Hampshire. For those of you who always wanted to know the secret to their popular spicy black beans side dish, it's this: hot pepper jelly. No, you didn't miss anything. That's truly it. You can go with a can or three of precooked ones, or cook up the dried version plain in the Crock-Pot. Either way, when they are done and drained, just add an appropriate amount of hot pepper jelly for that extra level of yum. Of course, to keep this affordable you'll need access to an affordable supply of really good pepper jelly. I recommend canning your own.

5. No-knead batter bread

For those who think this is not a stylish dinner side, I encourage you to take note next time you visit Olive Garden or Macaroni Grill. People blow through bread sticks

and Italian bread like crazy. That being said, most don't always have the time to do the full knead-and-rise scene. Recommended solution? Try including simple batter breads into your menu repertoire. If you go with a once-a-month dry-mix assembly plan, all of these can be put together with less stress than many casseroles. And, if you add in some meat and veggie leftovers from last night's dinner, you can easily skate on the rest of the meal with a simple broth soup or bisque.

6. Three-ingredient salad

If salad is high on your list of dinner side preferences, your produce budget can become a serious issue. Consider keeping the base salad low-key with a simple spring mix, grape tomatoes, and sliced onions. This will give you a good base with dramatic color variations and very little cutting and chopping (I put my grape tomatoes in whole, which has the added benefit of soggiess prevention). Round it out as you see fit using your favorite add-ins that don't need to be used up right away, such as sunflower kernels, corn, or other crispies. Finish it off with an easy berry vinaigrette and you'll be rolling with nutrition and a punchy presentation. — **Myscha Theriault**